

Drive Image 7

Speed Junkie

Drive Image 7 is another popular imaging utility. What was really impressive about it was its speed—it beat the pants off Norton Ghost in the performance tests. Drive Image, like Norton Ghost, supports creation of images to multiple removable storage media such as CDs and floppies, as well as creation of images across a network. It also lets you break up the image file into 640 MB chunks so it fits on multiple CDs.

A feature thats unique to Drive Image is the ability to create disk images at scheduled times. You can create backup jobs, which hold all the information regarding the data to be backed up and the destination. Now the backup jobs can either be scheduled to run at various intervals or invoked manually from the backup jobs section.

On the interface front, Drive Image has a very simple interface that can be switched between Basic and Advanced view. This means that users who are familiar with the program can perform complex tasks faster, without using the wizards. There is support for compression of images built-in. The user can choose between three levels of compression—standard, medium and high.

For advanced users, Drive Image 7 has a utility that lets you view partition information, utilities that let you backup and restore the MBR, and a utility to clean the boot sector. The last one is particularly helpful when trying to recover a disk from boot sector virus infections.

Though Drive Image 7 as many features as the high-profile Norton Ghost, it zooms past in performance tests. Just goes to show us that not much lies in the name or banner; the performance is where it's at!

+ Fast image creation and restoration, scheduling of backups possible
- No updating possible

Drive Image 7
Performance
Features
Ease of use
Overall

Conclusion

Overall, both these imaging tools provide similar features and equally simple interfaces, but Drive Image 7 provides an advanced view that is helpful for users who'd like to bypass the wizards. In the case of Norton Ghost, the only options available for advanced users are command line options—this could be daunting for most users. In terms of compression, Norton Ghost provides better compression at default settings. The real differentiating point is the time performance figures: Drive Image took about half the time to carry out the same operations.

CATEGORY	IMAGING SOFTWARE	
Product	Symantec Norton Ghost 2003	PowerQuest Drive Image 7
Ease of Use	24	17.25
Installation (Scale of 5)	4	4
Configuration (Scale of 5)	4	3.5
Interface (Scale of 5)	4	4
Updating (Scale of 5)	4	0
Features	27	27
Backup on removable media	✓	✓
Backup on network drive	✓	✓
Drive-wise image creation	✓	✓
Partition-wise image creation	✓	✓
Individual file extraction from images	✓	✓
Restore to different location	✓	✓
Cloning	✓	✓
Separate Image Integrity check	✓	✗
Image Explorer provided	✓	✓
Scheduled image creation	✗	✓
Performance	13.67	20.81
Backup Time (seconds)	336	183
Restore Time (seconds)	285	189
Compression (%)	52	70
Total	64.67	65.06
Web site	www.symantec.com	www.powerquest.com

ROLLBACK SOFTWARE

This category consists of utilities that restore your computer to a previously backed-up restore point. A Windows crash is a regular experience for PC users. Sometimes, even a single corrupt file can bring down your entire system—in such a situation, rollback utilities take you back in time to a point where everything was fine.

RestoreIT

Restore automatically

RestoreIT is easy to install. It needs a separate partition for holding the backup image. If your hard disk does not have free space for a new partition, the installation procedure automatically resizes the existing partition to make space. It modifies the Master Boot Record (MBR), so that the software gets control of the machine before the Windows boot loader does. So, even if an entire partition gets erased, you can restore the partition without the need for any bootable media. If the MBR gets erased, however, RestoreIT cannot restore the partition—because if the MBR is overwritten, RestoreIT won't be able to boot itself up.



Restore IT lets you do incremental or static backups of data

RestoreIT regularly creates incremental backups each time you start your machine. If you do not shut down your machine frequently, it still makes an incremental backup once a day. If you want to, you can schedule the software to automatically restore the parti-